After Independence from the British in 1947 and Portugal in 1961, many traditional occupations of Goan migrants in the Indian subcontinent were curtailed. The Goans increasingly began to migrate outside India. Over the next five decades, overall outmigration intensities reduced but were still high in traditional hotspots such as Bardez and Salcete, where 30 per cent of households received international remittances. In recent years, nearly 60 per cent of Goan emigrants were reported to be working in the Gulf countries and many men were found to be working in no man's land—the oceans—as part of the merchant navy.[40]

Below Goa lies the Canarese region, which includes Udupi, and farther south is Kerala, now known for high circular migration just like the circularity of its language: Malayalam, a palindrome. While the 'Mallu' connection with outmigration is the butt of far too many jokes today (mass migration, after all, is quite the pheno*menon*), Kerala surprisingly entered the Great Indian Migration Wave relatively late. For a while in the early 20th century, Kerala was a region of net inmigration due to the plantations in Wayanad and Idukki.[41] Other forms of mobility existed, for instance, the settlement-based migrations from Travancore–Cochin in the south to Malabar in the north, or migrations towards Sri Lanka. Since the 1930s, male-dominated outmigration picked up towards various Indian cities, especially Mumbai. The first authoritative account of Mumbai's migrants was written in 1968 by one such male migrant, a Syrian Christian Malayali demographer, K.C. Zachariah, who would become the doyen of migration research in India.[42] But the floodgates of mass male migration from Kerala opened only in the 1970s with the surge in demand for labour in the Gulf countries following a hike in oil prices. Kannur and Thrissur districts were early entrants to the wave but by the end of the 20th century all districts participated in the migration wave and nine out of ten emigrants went to the Gulf. Within the Gulf, Saudi Arabia and the United Arab Emirates each absorbed a third of Kerala's emigrants. The others were distributed across Oman, Kuwait, Bahrain and Qatar.

We know more about Kerala's mass migration wave than any other part of India because of a series of pioneering migration surveys conducted by